Causes of the Great War (1871–1914)

KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL & HOMEWORK COMPANION • 30 HIGH-YIELD QUESTIONS

Pupil Name: _____ **Class:** _____ **Teacher:** _____



The Royal Navy battleship HMS Dreadnought (c. 1906–1907) • Revolutionary steam turbine propulsion and ten 12-inch guns triggered the Anglo-German naval arms race.

LESSON ENQUIRY FOCUS	HW DUE DATE	1. SOLO (WRITTEN)	2. PARTNER (VERBAL)	PARENT / TEACHER SIGN
Enquiry 1: German Unification & Revanche 1871 German Unification, Franco-Prussian War, annexation of Alsace-Lorraine, French revanche & Otto von Bismarck		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 2: Imperial Rivalry & Morocco Kaiser Wilhelm II, Weltpolitik, Scramble for Africa, 1905 Tangier Crisis & 1911 Agadir Crisis (SMS Panther)		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 3: Naval Arms Race & Dreadnought 1906 HMS Dreadnought, Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz, German Naval Laws, Two-Power Standard & North Sea blockade plans		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 4: Alliances & Balkan Powder Keg Triple Alliance, Triple Entente, Ottoman decline, Balkan Powder Keg & 1908 Austrian annexation of Bosnia		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 5: Sarajevo & The July Crisis 28 June 1914 Sarajevo assassination, Gavrilo Princip, German 'Blank Cheque', Schlieffen Plan & British entry		/ 6	/ 6	

HOW TO COMPLETE YOUR RETRIEVAL CYCLES:

1. SOLO (WRITTEN): Complete your 6 write-in lines from memory without looking. Check your answers in green pen using the Department Marking Bank on Pages 7–8.

2. PARTNER (VERBAL): Hand your booklet to a **PARENT, CARER, FAMILY MEMBER, OR STUDY BUDDY** to test you out loud from the Marking Bank until you hit 6/6!

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Access online self-marking retrieval flashcards, diagnostic feedback, and audio narration at the-history-revision-hub.netlify.app.

Enquiry 1: German Unification & Revanche

How did German unification and the Franco-Prussian War divide Europe?

QUESTIONS 1–6

1862–71 Blood & Iron Wars → **Jan 1871** Empire Proclaimed → **May 1871** Alsace-Lorraine Ceded → **1871–90** Bismarckian Isolation → **1890** Bismarck Dismissed

1. Which powerful military kingdom united the 39 German states under Berlin in 1871? [Prussia / Bavaria]

Fact: _____

This meant that... _____

2. Which mineral-rich French border territory was seized by Germany following the Franco-Prussian War?

Fact: _____

Because... _____

3. Why was a "war on two fronts" the German military's greatest strategic nightmare?

Fact: _____

Because... _____

4. How did Chancellor Otto von Bismarck use "Blood and Iron" diplomacy to protect the new German Empire?

Fact: _____

By... _____

5. Why did Kaiser Wilhelm II's dismissal of Bismarck in 1890 trigger a European diplomatic crisis?

Fact: _____

This meant that... _____

6. How did the creation of the German Empire in 1871 permanently destabilize the European balance of power?

Fact: _____

As a result... _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Prussia | Alsace-Lorraine | Revanche | Blood & Iron | Two-Front War | Balance of Power

1884–85 Berlin Conference → **1898** Fashoda Incident → **1904** Entente Cordiale → **1905** Tangier Crisis → **1911** Agadir Crisis

7. ► **What phrase describes Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive demand for an overseas German colonial empire?**

[A "place in the sun" / "Splendid Isolation"]

Fact: _____

Because... _____

8. ► **What term describes the rapid colonisation and partition of the African continent by European powers (1881–1914)?**

Fact: _____

Because... _____

9. ►► **Why did Kaiser Wilhelm II land at Tangier in 1905 to trigger the First Moroccan Crisis?**

Fact: _____

To... _____

10. ►► **Why did Germany send the gunboat SMS Panther to Agadir during the Second Moroccan Crisis in 1911?**

Fact: _____

Because... _____

11. ►►► **Why did the two Moroccan Crises ironically strengthen rather than weaken the Anglo-French Entente?**

Fact: _____

Because... _____

12. ►►► **To what extent did imperial rivalry in Africa make a general European war more likely?**

Fact: _____

As a result... _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Scramble for Africa | Weltpolitik | A Place in the Sun | Tangier | Agadir (SMS Panther) | Entente Cordiale

1889 Two-Power Standard → **1898–00** German Naval Laws → **1906** HMS Dreadnought → **1908–09** Naval Scare → **1912** Haldane Mission Fails

13. ► **Which revolutionary, all-big-gun British battleship launched in 1906 rendered all existing warships obsolete?**

[HMS Dreadnought / SMS Panther]

Fact: _____

Because... _____

14. ► **Which German Admiral directed the rapid expansion and modern construction of the High Seas Fleet?**

Fact: _____

By... _____

15. ►► **Why was unquestioned naval supremacy a matter of life and death for Great Britain?**

Fact: _____

Because... _____

16. ►► **What was Admiral Tirpitz's "Risk Theory" (Risikotheorie)?**

Fact: _____

The idea that... _____

17. ►►► **Why did the launch of HMS Dreadnought ironically endanger Britain's established naval supremacy?**

Fact: _____

Because... _____

18. ►►► **How did the naval arms race permanently transform relations between Britain and Germany?**

Fact: _____

As a result... _____

KEY TERM VAULT: | HMS Dreadnought | Admiral Tirpitz | Two-Power Standard | Risk Theory | North Sea | Naval Laws

Enquiry 4: Alliances & Balkan Powder Keg

Did European military alliances protect peace or guarantee a continental catastrophe? **QUESTIONS 19–24**

1882 Triple Alliance Formed → **1894** Franco-Russian Pact → **1907** Triple Entente Formed → **1908** Bosnian Crisis → **1912–13** Balkan Wars

19. Which three nations united into the defensive Triple Entente by 1907? ►

[Britain, France, Russia / Germany, Austria, Italy]

Fact: _____

This meant that... _____

20. Which three empires formed the rival Triple Alliance signed in 1882? ►

Fact: _____

Because... _____

21. Why was the mountainous Balkan peninsula known as the "Powder Keg of Europe"? ►►

Fact: _____

Because... _____

22. Why was Serbia furious when Austria-Hungary annexed Bosnia-Herzegovina in 1908? ►►

Fact: _____

Because... _____

23. Why was the Bosnian Crisis of 1908 a fatal rehearsal for the outbreak of general war in 1914? ►►►

Fact: _____

Because... _____

24. How did the rigid alliance systems turn a local Balkan confrontation into a world war? ►►►

Fact: _____

As a result... _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Triple Alliance | Triple Entente | Powder Keg | Bosnian Crisis (1908) | Pan-Slavism | Ottoman Decline

28 Jun 1914 Sarajevo Assassination → **5–6 Jul** German "Blank Cheque" → **23 Jul** Austrian Ultimatum → **28–30 Jul** Russian Mobilisation → **4 Aug 1914** Britain Enters War

25. ► **Who was assassinated in Sarajevo on 28 June 1914, providing the immediate catalyst for the First World War?**
[Archduke Franz Ferdinand / Kaiser Wilhelm II]

Fact: _____

This meant that... _____

26. ► **What secret Serbian nationalist military society armed and trained the 19-year-old assassin Gavrilo Princip?**

Fact: _____

Because... _____

27. ►► **What unconditional pledge of military backing did Germany grant Austria-Hungary on 5 July 1914?**

Fact: _____

Known as... _____

28. ►► **What German military operational plan aimed to knock out France in six weeks before turning to face Russia?**

Fact: _____

Known as... _____

29. ►►► **Why did the German invasion of neutral Belgium directly force Great Britain to enter the war on 4 August 1914?**

Fact: _____

Because... _____

30. ►►► **Was the outbreak of war in August 1914 caused primarily by calculated political decisions or inflexible rail timetables?**

Fact: _____

Consequently... _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Franz Ferdinand | Gavrilo Princip | Black Hand | Blank Cheque | Schlieffen Plan | Treaty of London (1839)

Department Marking Bank • Part 1

Green-Pen Verification Key • Enquiries 1 to 3 (Questions 1 to 18)

ENQUIRIES 1–3

ENQUIRY 1: GERMAN UNIFICATION & REVANCHE

1. ► **Prussia** — *Prussia used its disciplined military, rail network, and industrial Krupp steel power to forge a united German Empire under Kaiser Wilhelm I.* [✓] [X]

2. ► **Alsace-Lorraine** — *Annexing this territory created an enduring French national desire for vengeance and restitution known as "Revanche".* [✓] [X]

3. ►► **It risked being attacked simultaneously by France in the west and Russia in the east** — *Germany feared its army would be split in two, leading Chancellor Bismarck to construct cautious alliances to isolate France.* [✓] [X]

4. ►► **Through decisive military victories followed by pragmatic alliances to keep peace** — *Bismarck believed great questions were decided by industrial military strength, but maintained peace through treaties like the Reinsurance Treaty with Russia.* [✓] [X]

5. ►►► **He abandoned Bismarck's cautious diplomacy and allowed the treaty with Russia to lapse** — *Dropping the treaty left Russia isolated and distrustful, prompting Tsar Alexander III to sign a defensive military alliance with democratic France in 1894.* [✓] [X]

6. ►►► **It placed a massive industrial and military giant directly in the centre of Europe** — *A united Germany instantly eclipsed older powers in population and coal-steel production, alarming Britain and driving France toward encirclement strategies.* [✓] [X]

ENQUIRY 2: IMPERIAL RIVALRY & MOROCCO

7. ► **A "place in the sun" (Platz an der Sonne)** — *Wilhelm II argued that Germany's rapid industrial growth entitled it to global colonial possessions equal to Great Britain.* [✓] [X]

8. ► **The Scramble for Africa** — *European powers seized 90% of Africa to control rubber, minerals, cotton, and strategic trade coaling stations.* [✓] [X]

9. ►► **To challenge French influence in North Africa and test the strength of the Anglo-French Entente** — *Wilhelm declared support for the Sultan of Morocco, hoping to humiliate France and drive a wedge between Britain and France, but his tactic failed.* [✓] [X]

10. ►► **To use "gunboat diplomacy" to extort French colonial territory in the Congo** — *Germany demanded French land in exchange for accepting French control over Morocco, prompting Britain to threaten war in Lloyd George's Mansion House speech.* [✓] [X]

11. ►►► **German bullying convinced Britain that Germany was a dangerous rogue state, prompting joint military talks** — *Rather than driving Britain and France apart, the crises led to secret joint military staff talks and a division of naval defense responsibilities.* [✓] [X]

12. ►►► **It convinced German leaders they were encircled and normalized aggressive brinkmanship** — *Repeated colonial confrontations conditioned European publics to expect armed conflict and accelerated peacetime army expansion.* [✓] [X]

ENQUIRY 3: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT

13. ► **HMS Dreadnought** — *Dreadnought carried ten 12-inch heavy guns and steam turbine engines, revolutionizing naval architecture overnight.* [✓] [X]

14. ► **Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz** — *Tirpitz passed the German Naval Laws (1898/1900) to build a battlefleet capable of challenging the Royal Navy in the North Sea.* [✓] [X]

15. ►► **As an island empire, Britain relied on merchant shipping for raw materials and to feed its population** — *A hostile naval blockade in the English Channel or North Sea would starve Britain within six weeks, making any naval challenge intolerable.* [✓] [X]

16. ►► **Building a fleet strong enough that fighting Germany would fatally weaken Britain's global empire** — *Tirpitz believed fear of losing naval mastery would force Britain to make diplomatic concessions and stay neutral in European wars.* [✓] [X]

17. ►►► **It wiped out Britain's enormous numerical lead in older pre-dreadnoughts, resetting the race to zero** — *By making older battleships obsolete, Germany could compete on equal terms by building only new dreadnoughts in modern shipyards.* [✓] [X]

18. ►►► **It turned friendly trading partners into suspicious rivals and drove Britain toward France and Russia** — *German naval expansion convinced British statesmen that Germany sought continental domination, ending British "Splendid Isolation".* [✓] [X]

Department Marking Bank • Part 2

Green-Pen Verification Key • Enquiries 4 to 5 (Questions 19 to 30)

ENQUIRIES 4–5

ENQUIRY 4: ALLIANCES & BALKAN POWDER KEG

19. ► **Great Britain, France, and Russia** — *Agreements between France, Russia, and Britain settled past imperial disputes and formed a diplomatic counterweight to Berlin and Vienna.* [✓] [X]

20. ► **Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy** — *The members promised mutual military assistance if attacked by two or more rival great powers.* [✓] [X]

21. ►► **Ethnic nationalism, crumbling Ottoman rule, and great power rivalry made it highly volatile** — *Newly independent Balkan states fought two Balkan Wars (1912–13) while Austria-Hungary and Russia competed to fill the Ottoman vacuum.* [✓] [X]

22. ►► **Bosnia contained a large Slavic population that Serbia wanted to unite into a "Greater Serbia"** — *The annexation frustrated Serbian nationalist dreams of creating a united South Slav kingdom and ignited intense anti-Austrian terrorism.* [✓] [X]

23. ►►► **Russia was forced to back down under German threats, vowing never to retreat in the Balkans again** — *The diplomatic humiliation accelerated Russian rearmament and ensured Russia would mobilize its full army if Serbia was attacked a second time.* [✓] [X]

24. ►►► **They chained the great powers together so that an attack on one ally triggered mandatory mobilization of all** — *Treaties transformed a localized Austro-Serbian quarrel into an uncontrollable continental chain reaction of military mobilizations.* [✓] [X]

ENQUIRY 5: SARAJEVO & THE JULY CRISIS

25. ► **Archduke Franz Ferdinand (heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne)** — *His assassination during an official inspection tour of Bosnia provided Austrian hawks with the long-sought pretext to crush Serbia.* [✓] [X]

26. ► **The Black Hand ("Unity or Death")** — *Led by Serbian military intelligence officer "Apis", the clandestine group sought to unite all South Slavs through armed insurrection.* [✓] [X]

27. ►► **The "Blank Cheque"** — *Kaiser Wilhelm II promised German military backing even if Austrian action against Serbia triggered war with Russia.* [✓] [X]

28. ►► **The Schlieffen Plan** — *The plan relied on invading neutral Belgium to bypass French border fortresses and encircle Paris rapidly, avoiding a prolonged two-front war.* [✓] [X]

29. ►►► **Britain had guaranteed Belgian neutrality in the 1839 Treaty of London and could not accept hostile Channel ports** — *When Germany refused to respect the "scrap of paper" treaty and invaded Belgium, Britain delivered an ultimatum and entered the war to defend the Channel coastline.* [✓] [X]

30. ►►► **A fatal combination of aggressive risk-taking by leaders and rigid military mobilization timetables** — *Once Tsar Nicholas II ordered general mobilization, German war plans dictated an immediate preemptive strike through Belgium, leaving zero time for diplomacy.* [✓] [X]

UNIT CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATIONS • 4 CORE ANCHORS

MILITARISM: The rapid expansion of armed forces, naval building, and military dominance over government policy (e.g. Dreadnoughts, Schlieffen Plan).

ALLIANCES: Formal diplomatic treaties committing powers to mutual military defence (Triple Alliance vs. Triple Entente), turning local crises continental.

IMPERIALISM: Great power competition for overseas colonies, prestige, and raw materials, exemplified by Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive Weltpolitik in Africa.

NATIONALISM: Fierce pride in one's nation and the drive of ethnic minorities (e.g. Slavic Serbs in the Austro-Hungarian Empire) for self-determination.